MCP

Title:
I Have Recently Returned from Killing the Second Hitler

Author:
J. Gone

© 2024 J. Gone
Publication Date: August 15, 2024

Published by
MUSHROOM CLOUD PRESS
An imprint of Rainbow Skull LLC
Made in the USA

Permission for performance of this piece is granted for the purpose of performance in competition by middle school, high school, and undergraduate collegiate performers. Online, remote, and video performances are permitted for these purposes only. Video or audio recordings of performances may not be shared or posted online without permission from the publisher. Theatrical performance and all other kinds of public performance, whether broadcast, online, or on stage, are prohibited without prior written permission from Mushroom Cloud Press, an imprint of Rainbow Skull LLC.

This script is authorized for competition only if the competitor or the competitor's representative, including but not limited to parent or educational entity, has purchased a copy of the script from Mushroom Cloud Press or an authorized retailer. The script must be presented with the cover sheet bearing the ISBN. Additional requirements for performance may be made by tournament and league rules.

Tournament officials: please contact Mushroom Cloud Press to validate script purchase.

For all inquiries and to see our full catalog of scripts, visit
MushroomCloudPress.com

Author's Notes

Different schools and organizations have different rules about hateful language. This play can be performed under its alternative title, "I Have Recently Returned from Committing a Great & Horrible Deed," if necessary. However, the language in the play around "The Second Hitler" should not be changed.

It is the author's intent that this play can be performed by an actor of any gender. As such, when the main character refers to himself as resembling an "uncle," this line can be changed to "aunt." In addition, the genders of the spouses can be changed in the text of the story, if the performer desires. No further changes are permitted.

I Have Recently Returned from Killing the Second Hitler
by J. Gone

People who now live, rejoice! The dark pool of possibility sitting in the shadow of your heart can remain hidden, for now. You do not need to extract the best or worst of yourself and perform great and terrible deeds merely to survive. Isn't that nice? To have a day where you will not be challenged to pick between a life of evil or a deed of martyrdom. Because. I have done a such deed on your behalf, and ask, briefly, for your undivided attention.

I have just returned from time-traveling into the past, where I killed a young American girl who was to become the Second Hitler.

The mission to kill the Second Hitler was not my idea. Its desperate architects only brought it to me as their plan neared completion. They did not choose me for any particular skill I possessed. Rather, I bore an uncanny resemblance to my target's close uncle, as he appeared 30 years ago. That coincidence allowed me a better chance to get in close to her, where I could engineer her downfall.

It was an easy choice for me. All my friends and loved ones were dead or banished. The few souls I knew alive, if they were not being tortured for information, were broken or in hiding. A few of course were the torturers.

This was six months ago. A different six months ago.

When most of you were dead. When a few of you held the whip, the chain. Maybe one of you still fought. There were not many of us.

I had no choice but to go backwards and kill this six-year-old girl.

The death went off as planned, well-choreographed. I was not nervous about the outcome. Had I been discovered, I would have set off a small explosive as a back-up option. Knowing all that would happen if the Second Hitler lived, I had no problem with the possibility of sacrificing myself to stop her.

I did receive a small shock when I raised my hand to do the deed. I should not have been surprised at what I saw. It's logical that if I looked like the girl's uncle, she would look like

me. But it turns out, the second Hitler looked just like my daughter. The act would have been disorienting only for the reason of surreal resemblance, were it not for the additional time traveler's consideration that killing this young girl would irrevocably change the future, perhaps wiping out the actions that led to my daughter's conception and erasing her as well. Therefore, as my hand continued to move, I looked into the second Hitler's eyes and also seemed to look in my daughter's eyes for the last time.

I remained in the past long enough to watch the little girl die. We were alone. I had to be sure. At first, I regarded her coldly as the life ran out of her. A monster, larval. But. Was that life good or evil now? Was she still as innocent as my daughter? So, I held the second Hitler's small hand as she left the world untouched by what she would become.

The device the architects created only brought me to the past for a certain, preset length of time, after which it returned me here. They had timed it perfectly. I heard commotion in the hall just before I felt the great heartache of time travel take my body and pull me forward through a billion new choices toward the new world. When I arrived here, the device dissolved.

I am pleased to report that the Second Hitler remains dead in our time. Her passing at age 8 is recorded as an accident in the official records and archived newspapers, and I found no follow-up articles regarding suspected foul play.

Thanks to this action, her reign of terror, under which we all lived - and many of you died - never came to be. I am reluctant to go into detail about how and what she did. History, as she proved, replicates itself so cleverly. All I will say is, no terror is impossible. Lay out all the worst things you can think of happening to you, or to your family, or to your country. Can you truly discount any of them taking place? Only by the rules of reasonable doubt and denial can we live without unending fear. Certainly, my mind will not find that peace again.

As for her political movement, that caused the deaths of tens of millions of you, it still exists, but in such a different form that I find it laughable. Some of the names of its members I recognize, obviously. As her adherents they would be butchers, but now they are only bureaucrats. She drew the evil out of them and put it on display for the world.

My partners, the women who invented the time-travel device, both live different lives, having never been called upon by terrible circumstances to develop their technology. They

did not share the details of the device with me, so I would be of no help to someone who attempted to recreate it - or, perhaps more accurately, attempted to create it now for the first time. I have honored their request not to try.

I went to one of the inventor's talks, on a matter related to entropy and neutron fields. Though she did not know it, she was explaining a part of the technology that had saved the world. Two of the greatest heroes stood in the room, she and I, but she didn't know that. I dare not tell her.

I didn't feel like a hero at all. After you've done something, good or bad, that cause and effect exist in the past, forever chasing each other in a loop, cat and mouse. The scientist's work made that connection between the entropy and fields: Cause and effect are manipulated, until you can climb them like ladders back to what had happened long ago. Going back in time through all that happening feels like being squeezed through a tiny cave, decisions crushing you on every side.

I did speak to the scientist after her talk when she came off the stage. I said, doctor, I had a different family in a different universe. She looked at me with pity, though there was the crimson sparkle of wonder. I suppose she knew what her work could mean, even in this timeline. Tell me more, she said, but I told her I promised that I would not. She smiled and snapped back into a polite handshake. She'd prepared for this moment, in a daydream here or there.

And I bet many of you have daydreamed of killing someone evil to save the world. As far as you know, that's all I'm doing. Describing a rather vivid daydream. As far as I know, none of this happened. If you have only your memory, and no other record of something important, then you must have tremendous trust in yourself. Faith that you believe in what you did.

Memory is faith, too. That what you did was real, was your choice. Memory is faith that, right or wrong, you would do it again.

Now that I've returned from killing the Second Hitler, my life, too, is changed. I find myself married to a different woman, with a new daughter. They seem like wonderful people, and I am looking forward to getting to know them. Fortunately, they have been very supportive of me and my new circumstances. They insist on it, because, they say, we have been a loving family for many years.

Since I returned from the past, I have often been tempted to contact my previous wife, but I would not know how to introduce myself. I miss her, of course. It would be hard for me, to see her, because the children we had together never existed. I bear that terrible fact for the sake of the world. The hardest part of carrying out my mission was knowing I could be erasing them. Up until the moment I returned, I held out hope that even in this new future, my wife and I would have found our way to each other, through some other story, and that my children would still greet me. Time doesn't work that way, though. Most things, you only get one chance.

For my children, it was at least a better fate than being killed in the reign of terror.

There is one friend, who died early in the early troubles, who I was so happy to find alive again. He had no idea why I was crying so much when I saw him.

Such happy reunions are happening all over. Perhaps between you and your family and friends. Though you don't know it. If you see someone you love when you leave this room, be sure to hug them as though they died a horrible death in the gulags of an alternate world. That's a good feeling we can always have, the escape from the embrace of a parallel universe. That our worst fears are only that.

I know for a fact that evil repeats itself. No one ever stops it completely. I tell my story only to give hope to those who face it the next time it returns. In the meantime, enjoy what you have been given. Who knows, you might be the other inventor responsible for the gift. You may have to make a choice, like I did.

I will not be answering further questions about the alternate timeline, for your sake and mine. I am taking some time off, to get to know my new family, and all that is different about our new world.

And perhaps, one day, I will go back to that lake, deep in the woods, where I used to spend the summers with my lost wife and our two dead children.